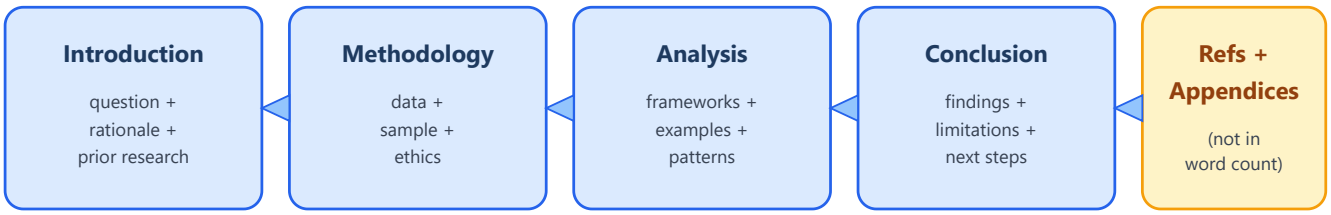
RAG Learning

3.1 Language Investigation (NEA)

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Non-Exam Assessment: Language in Action

> The Language Investigation is a **2,000-word research project** (excluding data, references and appendices) in which you investigate a language question of your choosing. It is half of the 20% NEA grade. A successful investigation has a focused **research question**, carefully collected **data**, clear **methodology**, theoretically-informed **analysis** at multiple linguistic levels, and honest **evaluation** of limitations.

Structure of a Language Investigation



3.1.1 Choosing a Topic and Research Question

Your topic should be something you find genuinely interesting, that you can collect data for, and that maps onto at least one topic from the spec (variation, change, gender, ethnicity, child development, pragmatics, etc.).

Common fruitful areas:

- **Representation** — how a group, event or topic is represented in media texts.
- **Occupational language** — the register of a specific profession or activity.
- **Digital/online language** — features of a particular platform, forum or app genre.
- **Child language** — development in a specific child (with consent).

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- **Gender and language** — in a specific context (classroom, podcast, advertising).
- **Regional / social variation** — features of a local variety in a bounded setting.
- **Language discourses** — analysis of texts about language.
- **Historical change** — comparing texts from different periods.

A good **research question** is:

- **Focused** — bounded enough to be answered in 2,000 words.
- **Answerable** — your data can actually speak to it.
- **Motivated** — you can explain why it matters (the rationale).

Weak question	Strong question
"How does language work?"	"How does the lexis of match commentary differ between men\'s and women\'s Premier League football on BBC Sport?"
"Is texting bad?"	"How do 16-18-year-olds use emoji to perform register shifts in WhatsApp messages with peers vs parents?"
"Do boys and girls speak differently?"	"What features of cooperative overlap appear in mixed-gender sixth-form classroom discussion?"

3.1.2 Data and Sampling

Primary vs secondary data

- **Primary data** — data you collect yourself. Examples: recorded and transcribed conversations; texts you gather from websites or newspapers within a defined window; survey responses.
- **Secondary data** — existing published sources used to frame your analysis. Examples: academic articles, corpus data (BNC, COCA), books by relevant theorists, quality journalism about your topic.

Sampling approaches

Sampling	Description	NEA relevance
Convenience	Accessible participants or texts you can reasonably obtain	Most common at NEA level. Acknowledge as a limitation.
Purposive	Deliberately selected to represent a particular category	Useful when studying a specific group (e.g. over-65 speakers).
Stratified	Sample drawn from defined sub-groups to ensure coverage	Good for comparative studies (age, class, gender).
Random	Each member of a population has equal probability of selection	Rarely feasible at NEA level; acknowledge if approximated.

Samples at NEA level are necessarily small. Generalisability is limited — this is not a weakness if you acknowledge and discuss it. What matters is demonstrating that you can apply linguistic methods rigorously.

3.1.3 Ethics

Whenever people are involved in your data, ethical considerations apply:

- **Informed consent** — participants (or parents/guardians for minors) know what the research involves and agree to take part. Keep signed forms in the appendices.
- **Right to withdraw** — participants can pull out at any time without penalty.
- **Anonymisation** — remove names and identifying details before analysis; use pseudonyms or codes.
- **Secure storage** — keep recordings and transcripts private during the research and delete or archive securely afterwards.
- **Vulnerable participants** — extra safeguards apply when working with children or anyone who might be at greater risk.
- **Public-domain data** (e.g. published newspaper articles, public broadcasts) is lower-risk, but always consider whether the people depicted might be identifiable.

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3.1.4 Transcription Conventions

If your primary data is spoken, you must transcribe it using conventional symbols. Jefferson-style conventions are widely used:

Symbol	Meaning
`(.)`	Micropause (<0.5s)
`(2.0)`	Timed pause in seconds
`[`	Overlap begins
`]`	Overlap ends
`=`	Latched utterance (no gap)
CAPS	Emphatic stress
`>quick<`	Faster-than-normal speech
`<slow>`	Slower-than-normal speech
`(( ))`	Transcriber\'s comment (e.g. laughter)
`:`	Sound elongation (e.g. "ye:s")

Transcription is selective — you can\'t capture everything. Choose a level of detail that fits your research question.

3.1.5 Applying Linguistic Frameworks

Your analysis must apply the six linguistic levels from 1.1:

- **Phonology / prosodics** — sound patterns, stress, intonation (if spoken data).
- **Graphology** — visual features (if written / multimodal data).

- **Lexis and semantics** — word choice, connotation, semantic fields.
- **Grammar and morphology** — sentence structures, agency, tense, aspect.
- **Pragmatics** — Grice, Brown & Levinson, speech acts.
- **Discourse** — cohesion, turn-taking, genre conventions.

Top-band investigations integrate levels rather than analysing each in isolation. Your analysis should move from evidence (quotations from data) → framework (precise terminology) → interpretation (what this means) → link to theory (how this fits or challenges prior research).

3.1.6 Quantitative and Qualitative Analysis

Most strong investigations use **mixed methods**:

- **Quantitative** — counts, percentages, frequency patterns, coded categories. Useful for showing patterns across your data.
- **Qualitative** — close analysis of specific examples, explaining HOW a feature works and what it means in context.

Percentages alone are not enough — "80% of tags were facilitative" only becomes meaningful when you analyse specific tags in their interactional context. Equally, close qualitative analysis of three examples is richer when placed in a quantitative context of how typical those examples are.

3.1.7 Writing Up — Section by Section

Introduction (c. 300 words)

- State your research question.
- Give the rationale — why does this matter?
- Reference 2-3 key prior studies or theorists.
- Set out your approach at a high level.

Methodology (c. 300 words)

- Describe your data: source, size, date range, collection method.

- Explain your sampling strategy and justify it.
- State how you transcribed and coded the data.
- Address ethics: consent, anonymisation, storage.
- Acknowledge observer\'s paradox or other methodological issues up front.

Analysis (c. 1,100 words)

- Organise by theme or linguistic level — choose what serves the argument.
- Each paragraph: evidence (quotation) → framework label → interpretation → theoretical link.
- Use numbered examples and reference appendices for longer quotations.
- Mix quantitative patterns with qualitative examples.

Conclusion (c. 300 words)

- Answer your research question explicitly.
- Summarise your key findings.
- Discuss limitations honestly — small sample, observer effect, coder bias.
- Suggest further research.

References

- Use Harvard referencing (or another consistent style).
- Include every source cited in the body of your investigation.
- Include at least 5-8 references for a strong investigation; a mix of theorists and empirical studies.

Appendices

- Full transcripts or data set.
- Coding frame.
- Consent forms (anonymised).

3.1.8 Evaluating Your Own Investigation

An honest evaluation is rewarded, not penalised. Typical things to discuss:

- **Sample limitations** — size, demographic, convenience bias.
- **Methodological limitations** — observer\'s paradox; single coder; short time frame.
- **Generalisability** — what can and cannot be concluded.
- **Biases** — your own expectations shaping selection or interpretation.
- **Further research** — how a larger, better-resourced study could extend your work.

> **Worked Example:** A student investigated the representation of young people in three UK tabloids over one week (21 headlines). They coded for topic (crime / achievement / entertainment), evaluative lexis, and grammatical agency. They found crime was the dominant topic (62%); evaluative lexis was almost exclusively negative; passives often obscured agency when youth were victims. Their analysis drew on Fairclough\'s CDA and Cameron\'s verbal hygiene. Their evaluation honestly acknowledged the short window, tabloid-only focus, and their own interest in media criticism as a potential bias. A focused, theoretically-informed piece of applied linguistic research that achieved a top-band grade.

3.1.9 Assessment Objectives

The NEA as a whole assesses the following AOs across the Investigation and the Original Writing:

- **AO1** — Apply appropriate methods of language analysis using associated terminology and coherent written expression.
- **AO2** — Demonstrate critical understanding of concepts and issues relevant to language use.
- **AO3** — Analyse and evaluate how contextual factors and language features are associated with the construction of meaning.
- **AO4** — Explore connections across texts informed by linguistic concepts and methods (relevant especially when comparing texts).
- **AO5** — Demonstrate expertise and creativity in the use of English (for the Original Writing component).

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NEA Tip: Investigations must be YOUR original work. Your teacher can advise on scope and methodology but cannot write or rewrite the piece. Keep good notes of your process — drafts, coding decisions, consent forms — for moderation.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **research question, hypothesis, primary / secondary data, sampling (convenience / purposive / stratified / random), informed consent, anonymisation, observer\'s paradox, triangulation, transcription conventions, coding frame, pilot study, mixed methods, qualitative / quantitative, limitations, generalisability, references (Harvard), appendices.**